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Exercise 4 – Prototype with Familiar and Unfamiliar Navigation Elements

Title: Student Academic Portal – Mobile Prototype

AIM

The aim of this exercise is to design and develop a mobile student academic portal prototype using Proto.io that integrates both familiar and modern navigation elements, and to evaluate their usability among different user groups.

OBJECTIVE

- To design a simple academic mobile application prototype.
- To implement familiar navigation patterns for ease of use.
- To introduce an unfamiliar navigation element for interaction testing.
- To evaluate usability across different age groups.

PROCEDURE

Step 1: Planning the Prototype

Before designing in Proto.io, the structure of the application was planned.

Identified Navigation Elements

Familiar Navigation Elements:

- Login screen with Email and Password fields
- Clear Login button
- Menu list with labeled options
- Profile screen layout
- Button-based navigation

Unfamiliar / Modern Navigation Element:

- Left Slide-in Hidden Navigation Menu

This hidden menu is not visible by default and appears only when the user interacts with the menu icon.

Step 2: Creating the Project in Proto.io

1. Logged into Proto.io.
2. Clicked on Create New Project.
3. Selected mobile device (iPhone model).
4. Named the project “uid exp4”.
5. Created three screens:
    - Screen 1 – Login
    - Screen 2 – Dashboard with Slide Menu
    - Screen 3 – Profile

SCREENS INCLUDED

The prototype consists of three main screens:

1. Login Screen
2. Dashboard Screen (Slide-in Menu)
3. Profile Screen

1. Login Screen

Features:

● Header with title “LOGIN”
● Email input field
● Password input field
● Login button

Navigation Type:

● Vertical aligned layout
● Large, clearly labeled button
● Tap interaction to navigate to next screen

Familiar Elements:

● Standard login form
● Email and password fields
● Clear call-to-action button

Purpose:

To allow users to securely access the academic portal.

2. Dashboard Screen (Slide-in Navigation Menu)

Features:

● Left Slide-in Hidden Menu
● User name displayed at top (HARSHINI)
● Menu options:
○ Home
○ Attendance
○ Marks
○ Profile
○ Logout

Navigation Type:

● Hidden side navigation
● Slide animation from left
● Tap-based interaction

Familiar Elements:

● Clearly labeled menu options
● Standard list layout
● Logout button

Unfamiliar / Innovative Element:

● Left Slide-in Hidden Navigation

Unlike traditional visible navigation bars, this menu remains hidden and appears only when the user interacts with it. This tests user adaptability and interaction awareness.

Purpose:

To provide structured access to different academic sections.

3. Profile Screen

Features:

- Header titled “Profile”
- Large rounded profile image
- Action buttons (Choose Photo / Take Photo)

Familiar Navigation:

- Profile image at top
- Button-based interaction
- Back navigation

Modern UI Elements:

- Large circular profile picture
- Clean and minimal spacing
- Centered layout

Purpose:

To allow users to manage and view personal profile information.

FAMILIAR NAVIGATION ELEMENTS USED

These elements improve usability:

- Login form layout
- Clearly labeled buttons
- Standard menu list
- Profile section structure
- Tap-based screen transitions

These patterns are commonly used in mobile applications, making them easy to understand.

UNFAMILIAR / INNOVATIVE ELEMENT USED

- Left Slide-in Hidden Navigation Menu

This navigation style is not immediately visible and requires user interaction to access menu options. It differs from traditional static navigation bars and evaluates how quickly users adapt to hidden navigation systems.

USER GROUPS FOR USABILITY TESTING

Users were divided into three groups:

1. School Students (13–17 years)
   - Basic technical knowledge
   - Comfortable with simple navigation
2. College Students (18–22 years)
   - Tech-savvy
   - Adapt quickly to modern UI
3. Teachers (25+ years)
   - Moderate technical experience
   - Prefer structured and visible navigation

USABILITY TESTING PROCESS

Tasks Given:

- Login using credentials
- Access menu from dashboard
- Navigate to Profile screen
- Return back to dashboard

Testing Method:

- Shared Proto.io preview link
- Observed task completion
- Collected feedback

OBSERVATIONS

Familiar Elements:

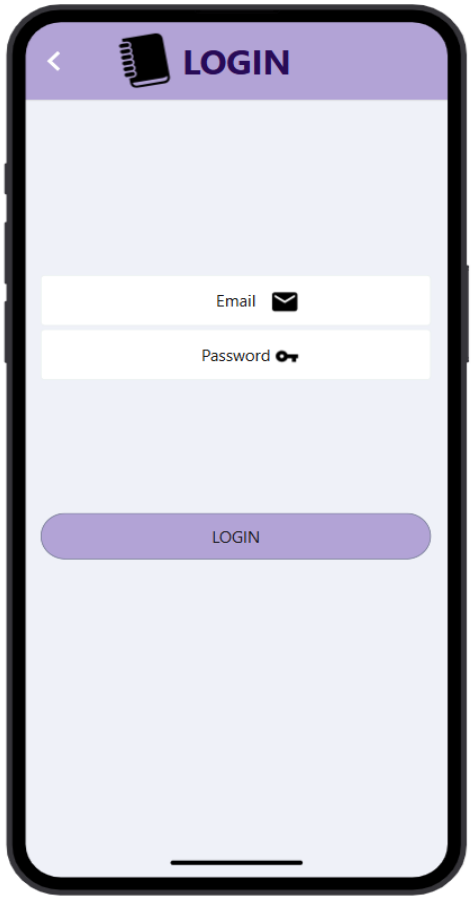
- All users easily completed the login process.
- Menu options were clearly understood.
- Profile screen was simple and clear.

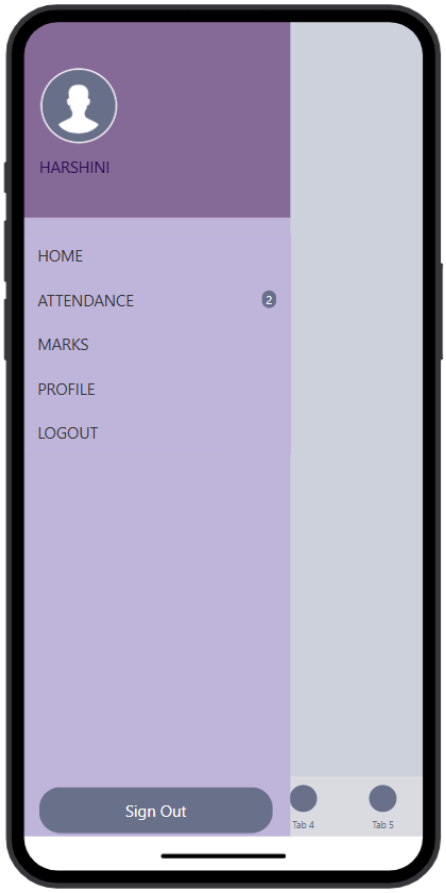
Unfamiliar Element:

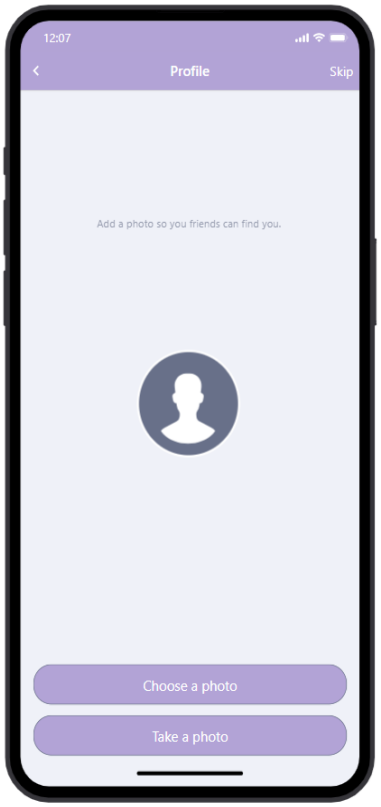
- Younger users quickly understood the slide-in menu.
- Some teachers initially searched for visible navigation.
- After first use, all users adapted easily.

ANALYSIS

- Familiar navigation ensured smooth usability.
- The slide-in hidden menu added modern interaction design.
- Users adapted quickly after initial interaction.
- Combining both navigation styles created a balanced and efficient mobile interface.



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